

Chapter 2 Leader Nationalism, Ethnic Identity, and Terrorist Violence

Abstract

When state leaders invoke nationalism in pursuit of legitimacy, they render disfavoured ethnic groups fearful of their future. In response, those groups are more likely to carry out terrorist attacks to survive. This chapter offers a theoretical argument, an empirical analysis, and a case study. I test the argument using a sample of 766 ethnic groups across 163 countries from 1970 to 2009. The multilevel mixed-effects negative binomial regression results provide evidence that leader nationalism is a significant driver of ethnic terrorism. The detrimental effect of nationalism remains unchanged after accounting for possible reverse causality. A case study relating Sinhalese nationalist leaders to the emergence of the Tamil Tigers supports these statistical results.